

Questions for Yuko Koshiba

Background: compiled from a Rob/Michael Goldberg/Elvin Zoet email thread (2026-07-10/11) ahead of a conversation with Yuko. Not a script — a working list to select from depending on how the conversation flows.

1. Her role and terms

- Pro bono, or would she need to charge a fee? If a fee, what structure (flat, retainer, % of funds raised)?
- Does she work as advisor/connector, or does she also help structure the receiving entity itself?
- She appears to operate on the donor/foundation side of the funding stack (advising funders on where to give) rather than as a fundraiser for projects — is that an accurate read of her practice, and does it change what kind of help she can offer us directly?

2. Incorporation and endorsement

- Do we need to incorporate before pursuing startup funding, or can early approaches be made informally?
- What forms of local government/organizational endorsement would strengthen an application, without putting a local body in control of the funds?

3. Coordination between funders

- Do Japanese foundations coordinate with each other, or with government grant programs, to co-fund different phases of one project (e.g. Foundation A funds production, Foundation B funds a later phase on condition A already committed)?
- Would a confirmed government grant (MoE/METI) make the project more attractive to a private foundation as a "first funder already in" precondition?
- Are matching-fund arrangements (foundation matches other contributions dollar-for-dollar up to a cap) common in Japan? Any she knows of relevant to reforestation/rural energy?

4. Fundraising coordinator role

- Does she know professional fundraising coordinators in Japan (commission-based, e.g. 15–20%) with rural/energy/environmental experience?
- Would she, or someone in her network, consider a coordinating role — and on what basis (fee, advisory, other)?

5. Entity structure and governance (raised by Elvin)

- The project's dual character — a commons element (forest, energy as a public good) plus commercial elements needed for funding/governance/sustainability — is currently planned as a two-tier structure: NPO holding a majority stake in a GK (see [mitsue_ga_crew_finance_entity_governance.md](#)). From her experience, does this kind of structure hold up in practice, or does an NPO top layer (membership, director, auditor requirements, voting rights) tend to add governance complexity that outweighs the benefit?
- Layering philanthropic/charitable funding on top of an already dual (commons + commercial) structure risks a specific failure mode: pro-bono or donated value effectively subsidizes the commercial side's margin — and if it doesn't, project viability depends on charity to bridge a break-even gap either way. Has she seen this play out in projects she's advised on, and how was it managed or avoided?
- Is there a simpler structure she'd recommend instead — e.g. splitting the project into standalone modules (AI data center / forest harvesting / energy generation), each with its own entity and business model, rather than one combined hybrid?
- If modules are split out, does that change which funder profile fits which module — e.g. AI data center as straightforwardly commercial, forestry/energy closer to a cooperative or non-profit model?

6. On the funding figures, if it comes up

- Current documents state a ¥192M funding target/pipeline with ¥0 raised or committed to date (as of 2026-07-11), and a ¥28M–¥53M gap if the target is fully realized. Worth confirming this framing reads clearly to a funder, not as an overstatement of progress already made.